

CHAPTER SUMMARY

- Don't even ask if you need a home inspection. Unless you're ripping the home down to the studs—which is a very interesting choice for your first house—the answer is always yes. Yes, yes, and triple yes. Schedule your home inspection as soon as you go under contract, so you won't miss any of your deadlines.
- Make sure you show up for at least the last hour of your inspection so you're able to walk through the property with the inspector and ask any questions. It might sound unnecessary when you're about to get a tome of a report, but being there in person is a complete game changer. Don't be afraid to ask the inspector whether something is a ten-dollar or ten-thousand-dollar problem, and make sure you finish up by asking their opinion on the house overall.
- We recommend getting a sewer inspection, but you can do this after the initial inspection. Same goes for radon, mold, asbestos, lead paint, or pest inspections if you or your agent think any of them are necessary.
- If a potential property operates on a septic system or well water or is in a floodplain, proceed with a little extra caution. These aren't the kinds of problems you'll want to deal with in the future—at least, not without the proper preparation.
- Though the worst-case scenario of home inspections is straight out of a horror movie, it's more likely that your inspection report will come back with a mix of small and big problems (or, if you're really lucky, just small ones). Your agent can help you decide which smaller issues are too small to even bring up in the objection notice.
- With each objection, you can ask the seller to either fix the problem or issue a credit at closing. We recommend the latter, since you want your house, health, and safety in your own hands.
- As much as it sucks, don't be afraid to walk away if the inspection reveals something horrible or if the seller won't budge on any of your requests. You win some, you lose some.